work'. Despite being told to go alone, he took an assistant and when they reached, they were told they had 24 hours in which to draft a demonetization ordinance. They were forbidden from communicating with RBI headquarters in Bombay. Fortunately, they managed to get a copy of the 1946 ordinance and used it to draft the new one! After the ordinance was drafted, it was sent to the President, N. Sanjiva Reddy, for assent.

On 16 January, the nation was informed through All India Radio's (AIR) 9 a.m. news bulletin that ₹1,000, ₹5,000 and ₹10,000 notes were being withdrawn from circulation. The bulletin added that all banks and treasuries would be closed the next day, 17 January 1978.

The Times of India reported that long queues formed in front of RBI and SBI offices from very early in the morning. Additional counters were set up but, according to the RBI history, 18 January '… started with utter confusion over the issue of declaration forms at the Reserve Bank headquarters at Bombay and working hours were stretched to 6.30 p.m.' Tempers were high, particularly among those in queues and foreign tourists who were stranded without cash.

Press reports suggested that many holders of high denomination notes did not turn up personally at bank branches to exchange them. Instead, they reportedly sold them to others who could present them at the bank with less suspicion. Various reports estimated that approximately ₹20 crore worth of high denomination currency notes were exchanged at a discount for small denomination notes.

The press also reported that, despite all precautions by the RBI, secrecy was not well maintained and ₹1,000 notes were already out of circulation a week before the demonetization announcement. It was also alleged that a large quantity of high denomination notes was sent to the Gulf countries a few days before the ordinance was announced, which, in due course, were presented to the RBI through official channels.[10]

Senior journalist Jay Dubashi wrote for the *India Today*, 'The move was directed at freezing the secret funds of politicians, especially